

(5) Methodist Church (Methodism)

BRIEF INTRODUCTION

The Methodist Church (Methodism) is a major Protestant denomination with approximately 70-80 million (2014 estimates) members (often called Methodists) worldwide. Methodism is founded by Anglican priest John Wesley (1703-1791) whose efforts in eighteenth-century England was focused on to revive the holy life of Christians according to the teaching of gospel within Anglican Church.

Rise of Methodism within Anglican Church was not due to some doctrinal dispute, but out of an emphasis on living the holy life according to its teaching. John Wesley (influenced by Moravian Church, Pietism and Arminianism) saw the failure of Anglican church, in calling sinners to repentance while people were perishing in their sins; and reaching out to the poor and needy. So, John along with his brother Charles Wesley and George Whitefield founded the movement (between 1739-1744 CE) when they started preaching to the crowds of working people on open-air in the outdoors (like in fields, farm houses, barns etc) with an emphasis on conversion and living a holy life guided by the Holy Spirit.

They established small groups or societies with new converts everywhere they went. These new societies met on regular basis for Bible study and to encourage and support fellow members in life of faith. Their emphasis on helping the poor and the average person and their very systematic approach of building the individual's life as holy, earned them the name Methodist from their opponent. Methodists stress on building loving relationships with others through social services such as establishment of hospitals, universities, orphanages, soup kitchens and organizations to train people to spread their faith.

The movement spread rapidly in England and America during eighteenth and nineteenth century. Methodism eventually separated completely from Anglican Church in 1784 CE. Through vigorous missionary campaign Methodist missionaries focusing on both evangelism and service, spread Methodism throughout the world.

This movement flourished in America where majority of the Methodists live today. Today large number of Methodists are also found in Zambia (3.9 million) South Africa (3.3 million), Nigeria (2.6 million), South Korea (2 million), Democratic Republic of the Congo (2.9 million) and West Africa (1.9 million).

Methodism, as a of Protestant denomination share the basic beliefs of most Protestant denominations.

In our following discussion we will focus only on unique aspects of Methodism and where there are differences with other Protestant denominations. So it is important to read upon 'Branches of Christianity' and 'Protestantism' in our website before proceeding any further.

SOURCES OF RELIGIOUS/SACRED INFORMATION

Methodism (like all other Protestant denominations) only considers the holy Bible as the source of religious/sacred information.

KEY FEATURES OF BELIEF

(Only the unique features of Methodism are discussed in this section)

The most distinguishing belief of Methodism from that of other Protestant denominations is the belief in the life of Christian perfection. John Wesley agreed with other Protestants reformer like Martin Luther, Zwingli and John Calvin that no one could earn salvation by works. But he however, taught that with God's sanctifying grace (the supernatural assistance) a Christian should work toward achieving a sinless life, turning away from temptation and sin, and performing works of piety and mercy. This aspect of Methodism was suspect to other Protestants, for whom it seemed too close to Roman Catholic doctrine of salvation by faith and works.

THE CHURCH

Methodist Churches use Connexional polity a derivative of Episcopal polity (clergy in local churches presided over by a bishop). Ministers are assigned to local churches by bishops (or chairperson) of a region. But unlike Episcopal polity Methodists typically give lay members representation at regional and national meetings (conferences) at which the business of the church is conducted. Which means a local church is never independent of the rest of 'The Methodist Connexion'.

~~The church structure is usually simple, plain and devoid of statues and images.

THE CLERGY

The Methodist church clergy is usually consists of Elders and Deacons. Methodist Church allows women to be part of the clergy and leadership position. There is no unified position on ordination of practicing homosexual clergy. Most Methodist Churches oppose ordination of homosexual clergy.

THE SACRAMENTS (OR ORDINANCES)

Methodists accept two sacraments: Baptism and Holy Communion.

Baptism: Methodists baptize both infants and adults.

Holy Communion: Methodist believe in the spiritual presence of Christ in the bread and wine. Most Methodists use non-alcoholic wine or grape juice instead of wine.

SALVATION

Methodists believe loss of salvation is possible for those who do not strive to make progress in living a life of Christian perfection. The profession of one's faith and growth in holiness are necessary for God's sanctifying grace to continue its work in him/her, and both of these are necessary elements for faith to be genuine and not compelled.

STATUES AND IMAGES

Methodists do not totally object use of religious statues and objects. Hence there is limited use of statues and images in Methodist churches.

CONTRACEPTION

Methodists allow responsible use of contraception.

ABORTION

Methodists allow abortion on certain reasonable circumstances.

DIVORCE AND REMARRIAGE

Methodists allow divorce and remarriage. Methodists position on this issue has changed over the years from its early strict divorce policy to today's rather liberal policy.

FOR MORE INFORMATION (Some Sources Used For This Article)

<http://www.newworldencyclopedia.org/entry/Methodism>,
http://www.bbc.co.uk/religion/religions/christianity/subdivisions/methodist_1.shtml,
<http://www.patheos.com/Library/Methodist>,
<http://christianity.about.com/od/devotionals/a/Methodist.htm>,
<http://www.umc.org/what-we-believe>,
<http://www.methodist.org.uk/who-we-are>,
<http://www.siouxcityfirst.com/283125>.

